their children born in India have to have registration certificates renewed on an annual basis. Those who entered India between 1959 and 2003 belong to an administrative category called ‘long term stay’. Since 2003, when India formally accepted Tibet to be a part of the People’s Republic of China, Tibetans are allowed to enter India through fewer checkpoints on a ‘special entry permit’ issued by the Indian embassy in Kathmandu in Nepal.

Tibetan refugees in India enjoy a large number of benefits, especially after the Tibetan Rehabilitation Policy of 2014. The economic success enjoyed by Tibetan settlements in agriculture, handicrafts, infrastructure and industry has been exceptional relative to other refugee groups in India. Obtaining Indian citizenship is not a high priority for many, unless they want to purchase land or property. An Indian court ruling in 2016 allowed Tibetans to apply for the Indian passport, but subsequent guidelines made this conditional on giving up refugee status and departure from the Tibetan settlements. Tibetans in India argue that this would make them settlement-less for the second time and, for the time being, it remains an unsettled issue.

Economic success and a strong sense of social cohesion did not mean that the ‘Little Tibets’ were untouched by Indian influences. Along with the daily prayers and traditional tasks, cable television slowly penetrated Tibetan settlements in the 1990s, bringing the hustle and bustle of Bollywood and television serials, and ideals of romance and love-marriage.[57] Second-generation Tibetans encounter all the issues associated with a diaspora, mainly a continuous negotiation with family and the larger society they live in. In northern Indian settlements, Hindi is spoken fluently, and young Tibetans increasingly consider themselves a ‘remix of Tibetan, Indian and Western’.[58]

In a surreal triangle connecting Lhasa, Dharamsala and Bylakuppe, over 1,00,000 Tibetans are dispersed away from their homeland. While ‘Free Tibet’ slogans still resonate, the official line is more subdued, accepting that Chinese rule is inevitable in the near future. This has eased Indo-China foreign relations to some extent. If the Tibetan cause shaped India’s foreign